

States **MAHARASHTRA**

must ensure the safety of its citizens. This debate has been going on for too long now and needs to be resolved."

Social activist Alyque Padamsee wonders whether the Congress is frightened of the Shiv Sena and the MNS, which is perhaps why Chief Minister Ashok Chavan is fortifying himself behind the walls of Mantralaya, while the Shiv Sena and the MNS are running wild burning taxis and beating up north Indians. He asks, "What has happened to law and order? Why is the prime minister not speaking out? There is a deafening silence from Delhi at a time when people are looking for answers."

With Assembly elections due in Bihar later this year, the rant against north Indians and Biharis by the parochial political class in Maharashtra has become a hot potato for both the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Congress at the national level. Not surprisingly, Chavan and the Congress did a U-turn on his policy on

RAHUL GANDHI

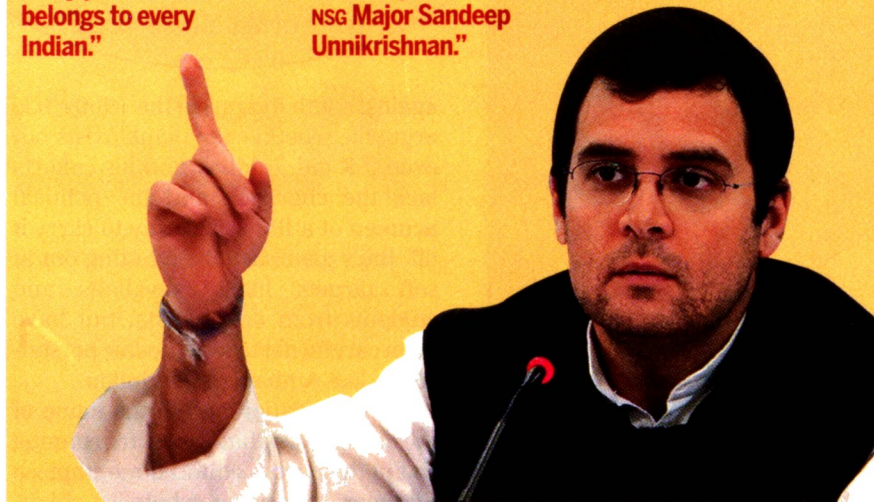
"I am not interested what Bal Thackeray or Raj Thackeray has said. I am interested in one concept that India belongs to Indians and every part of India belongs to every Indian."

UDDHAV THACKERAY

"Rahul Gandhi has insulted the bravery of martyrs like Hemant Karkare, Ashok Kamte, Vijay Salaskar, Tukaram Omble, all daring Marathi policemen, and NSG Major Sandeep Unnikrishnan."

BAL THACKERAY

"Mumbai may belong to all Indians but how can it belong to an Italian mummy?"



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CHAVAN
BACKTRACKED
ON HIS 'LICENCE
FOR LOCAL CAB
DRIVERS' WITHIN
24 HOURS

taxi licences for "locals only" within 24 hours. On January 31, Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat—a Marathi *manoos* in every sense of the Sena definition—delivered a huge body blow to the Sena by declaring that "Mumbai is for all Indians... nobody can prevent Indians from moving to any part of the country in search of employment". Always careful of its nationalist image, the RSS obviously decided to step in to stem the damage that its association with the Sena was wreaking on the BJP. Almost on cue, newly coronated BJP President Nitin Gadkari echoed the sentiments of the Sangh Parivar chief.

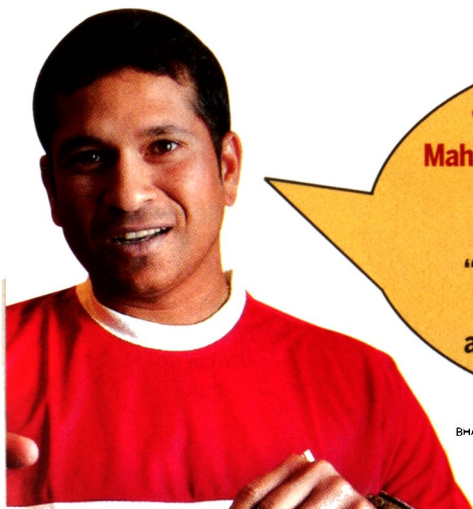
The babel of words has resulted in open sesame—everyone is taking an opportunity to score brownie points as politicians have elections to fight. Politicians and activists are competing in the studio-to-studio byte race. Raj declared he would be addressing a rally and the press on February 3. Within hours Uddhav, who had sworn off the press and found reason to praise the newly released *Rann* to criticise the media, also held a press conference. After reacting to Rahul's

SACHIN TENDULKAR

"Mumbai belongs to India. I am a Maharashtrian and I am extremely proud of that, but I am an Indian first."

SAAMNA

"You were not even born when the Marathi *manoos* got Mumbai and 105 Marathi people sacrificed their lives for it."



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